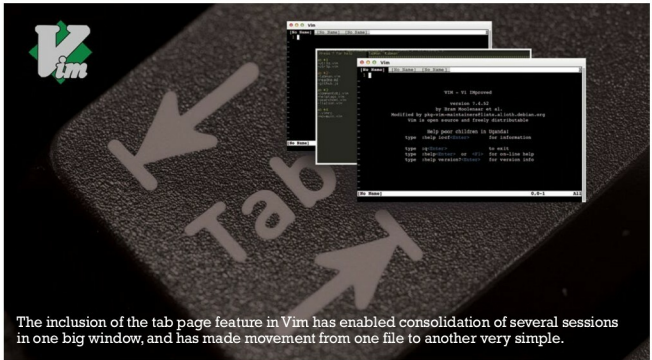


A Few Good Things about the Tab Page Feature in Vim



The inclusion of the tab page feature in Vim has enabled consolidation of several sessions in one big window, and has made movement from one file to another very simple.

Almost every graphical text editor provides a tab page feature. At first sight, it appears that Vim may have missed out on this hefty feature, but that's not true. Vim has great support for tab pages. It even allows the opening of multiple files under the same tab page via a window-splitting feature. The tab page feature was introduced in Vim in version 7.0 (released in May 2006). It is considered one of the best features of Vim. This column explores the tab page feature of the Vim editor. It is assumed that readers have some basic understanding of Vim.

Before delving deep into tab page features, let us understand how tabs are different from buffers and windows. Files store data on the disk in a persistent manner, whereas buffers reside in the memory. A buffer is an in-memory representation of a file. When we open any file in Vim, it is loaded into the buffer, and even when we perform any changes, we are actually modifying the buffer. For instance, the command below loads contents of the two files in separate buffers.

```
[bash]$ vim file1.txt file2.txt
```

We can easily switch to the next buffer by executing the `:bnext` command.

A window is a view-port into a buffer. Vim allows the viewing of multiple buffers side by side by dividing the

workspace into multiple windows. Each window can open the same or a different buffer. Windows can be split either horizontally or vertically. A tab page is just a collection of one or more windows placed side by side. We can also open multiple windows inside each tab page. Shortly, we will look at an example of the same.

Working with tab pages

Now that we have learned theoretical fundamentals of tab pages, it's time to do something practical. We can instruct Vim to open tab pages in multiple ways. One of the easiest is to open tab pages at start-up. The syntax of Vim's command-line argument to open multiple tab pages is given below.

```
vim -p[N]
```

In the above syntax, 'N' implies the number of tab pages and square bracket implies it's an optional parameter. To open three tab pages at start-up, use the command shown below.

```
[bash]$ vim -p3
```

Please note that `-p3` is a single word. This command opens three empty tab pages as shown in Figure 1.

Alternatively, we can also provide files to open them in